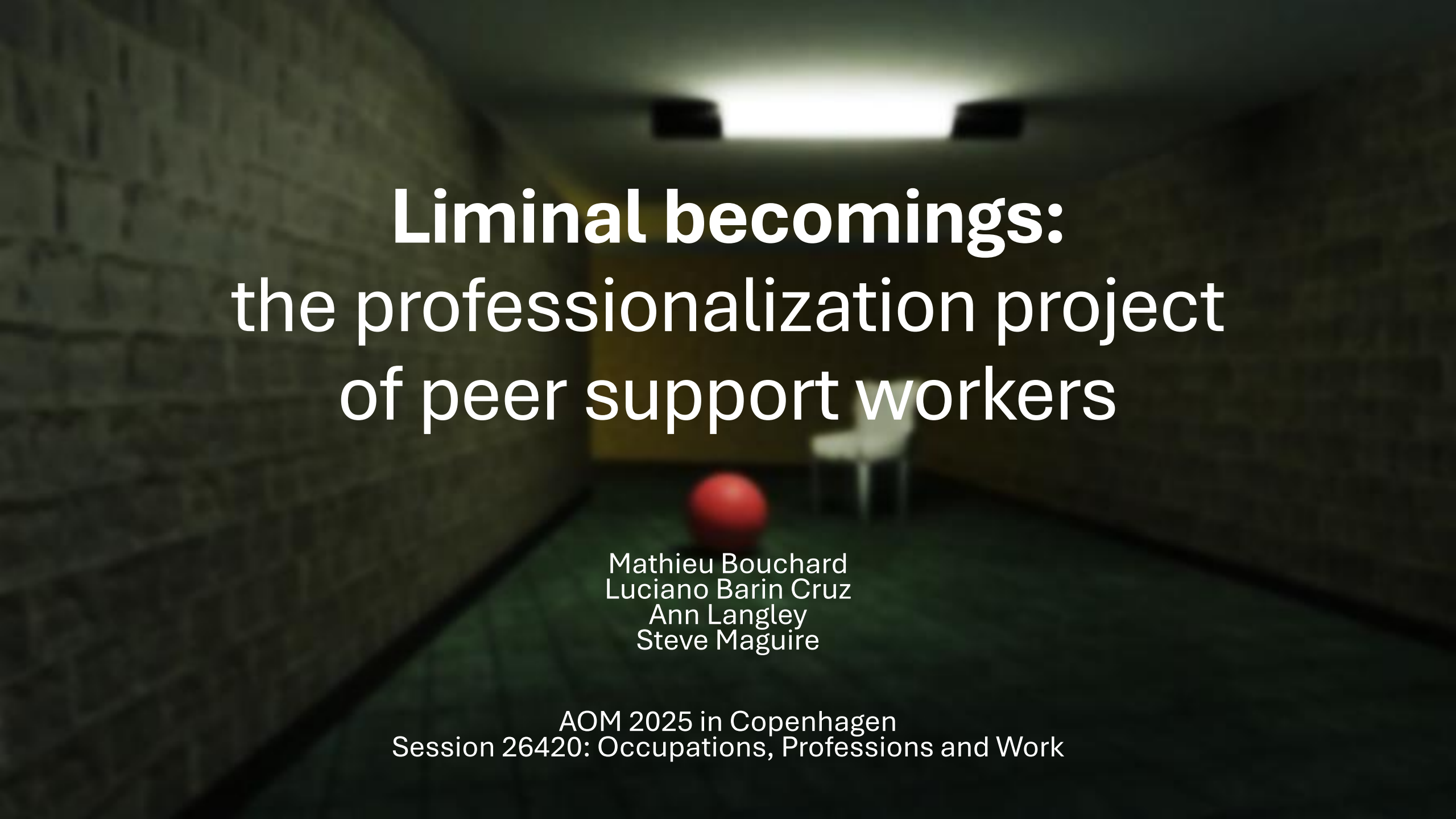


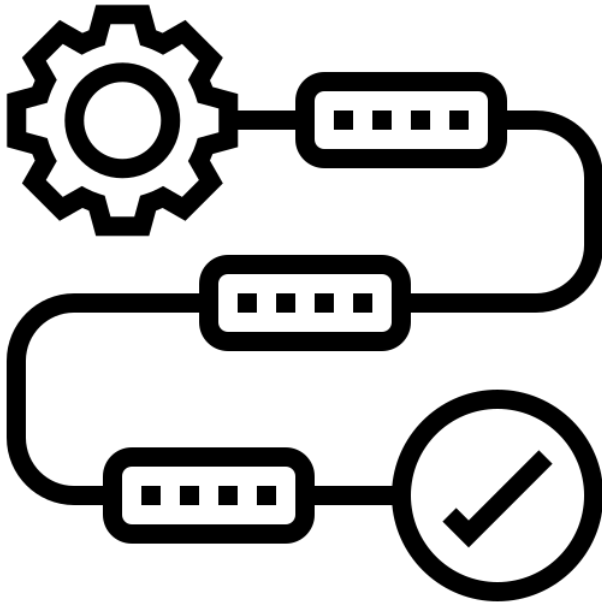
A dark, narrow hallway with a red ball on the floor and a bright light at the end.

Liminal becomings: the professionalization project of peer support workers

Mathieu Bouchard
Luciano Barin Cruz
Ann Langley
Steve Maguire

AOM 2025 in Copenhagen
Session 26420: Occupations, Professions and Work

Methods



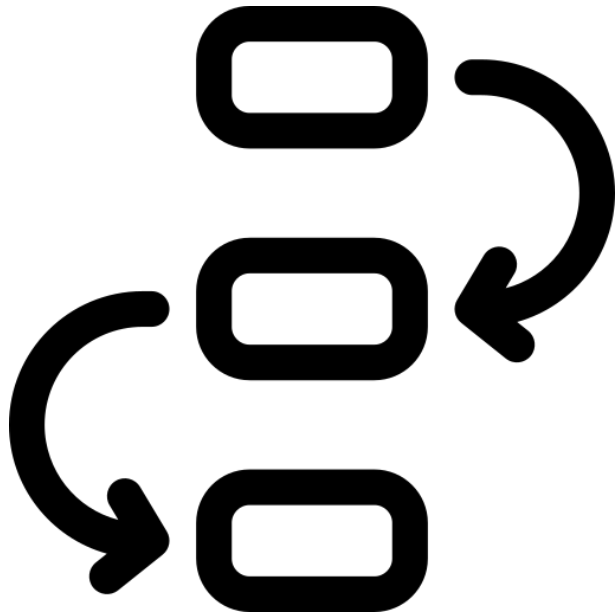
- 9-year institutional ethnography
- 127 observation notes and memos, 50 interviews, 92 historical and working documents collected during fieldwork
- Chronological analysis and temporal bracketing: visual representation of historical process in 2 periods and 4 phases

Empirical setting

- Peer support work is a healthcare role in-between the professional and the patient, is increasingly paid and credentialed
- Since 2005, peer support workers in Quebec have sought to professionalize their role in the healthcare system, with mitigated success
- The 1st author is a certified peer support worker who has been significantly involved with that community since 2015



Theoretical background



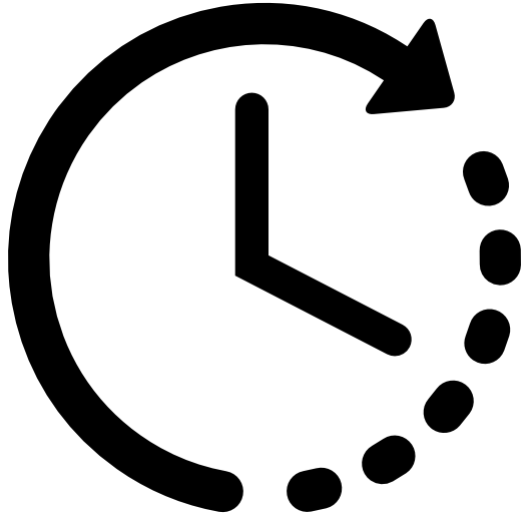
- Professionalization:
 - Knowledge
 - Association
 - Mandate and jurisdiction
- Liminality
 - In-betweenness
 - Time
 - Space

Research question

- How do “in-between” organizational spaces shape the becoming of professionalization projects over time?



Findings

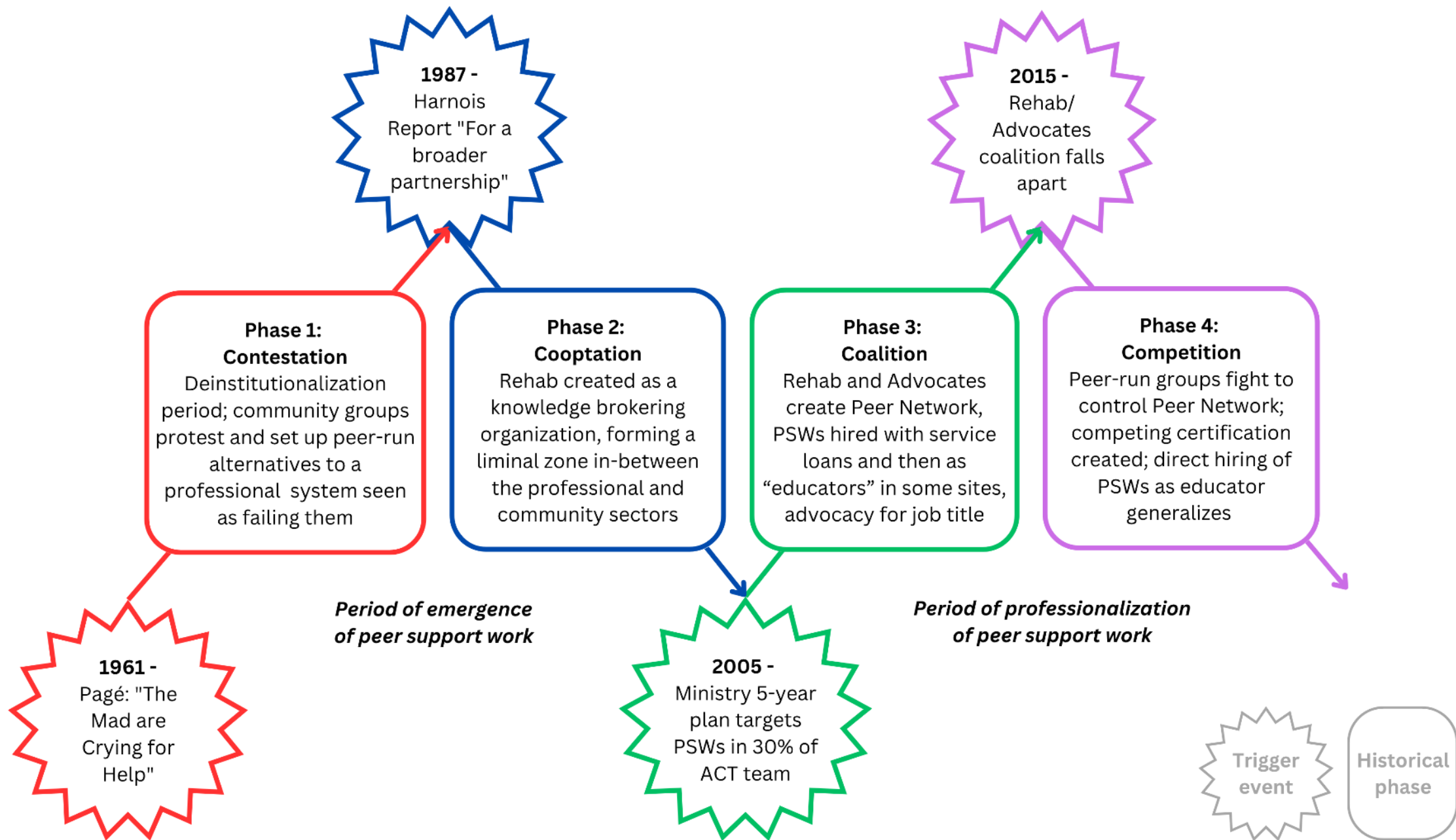


1961-2024: 4 phases in divided in 2 periods

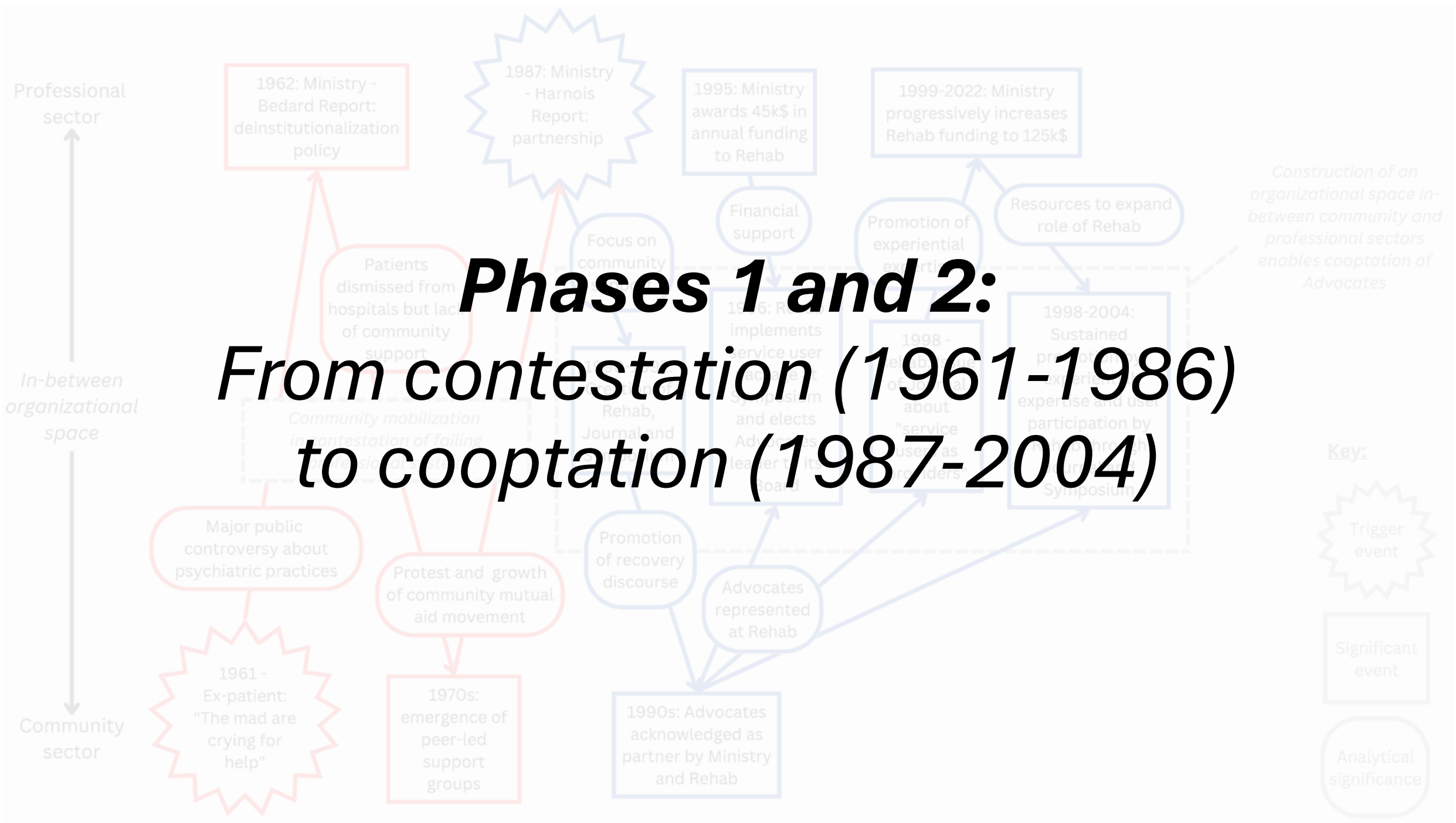
- Period 1: Emergence (1961-2004)
 - Contestation (1961-1986)
 - Cooptation (1987-2004)
- Period 2: Professionalization (2005-2024)
 - Coalition (2005-2014)
 - Competition (2015-2024)

Trigger events, periods, and phases

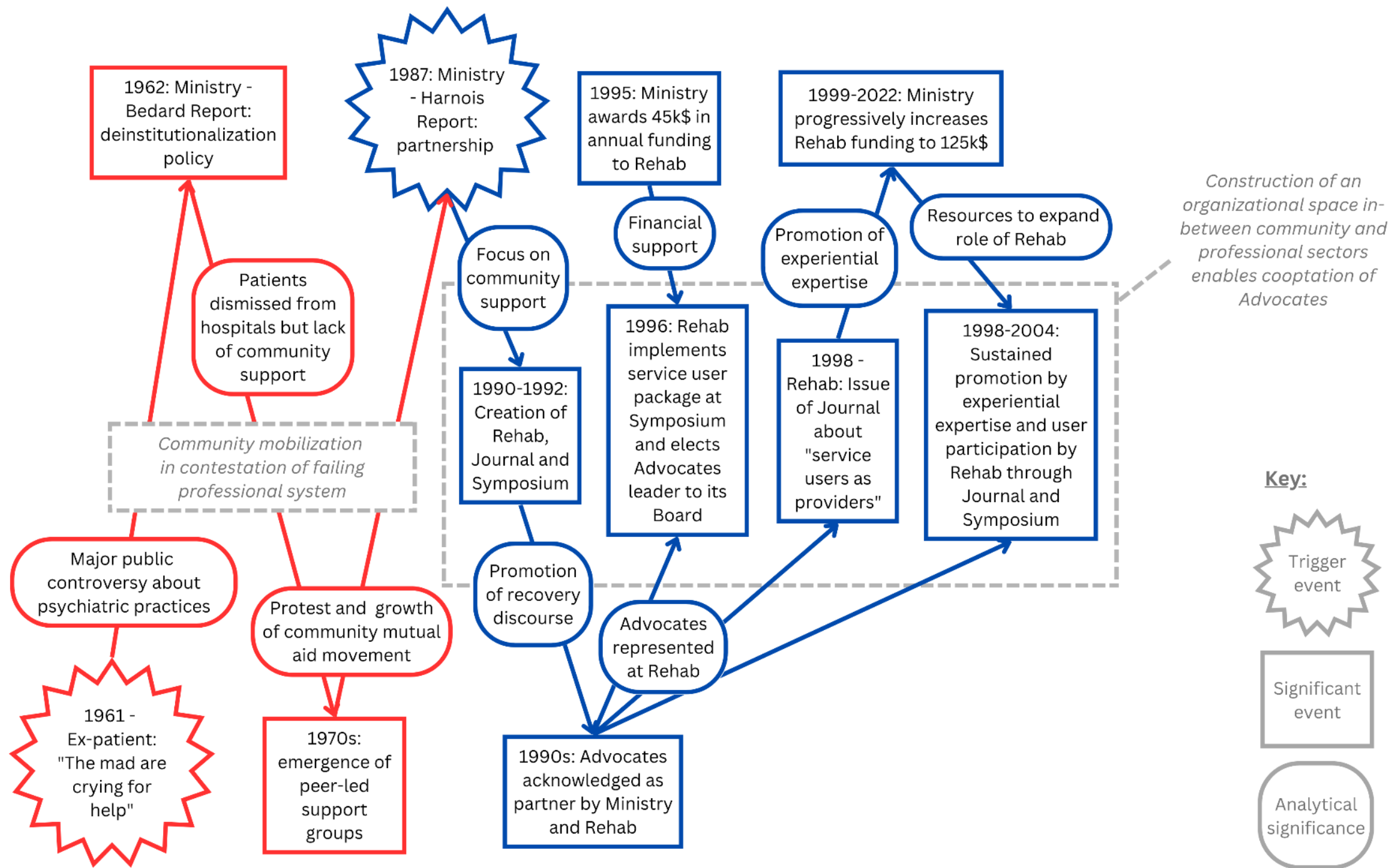




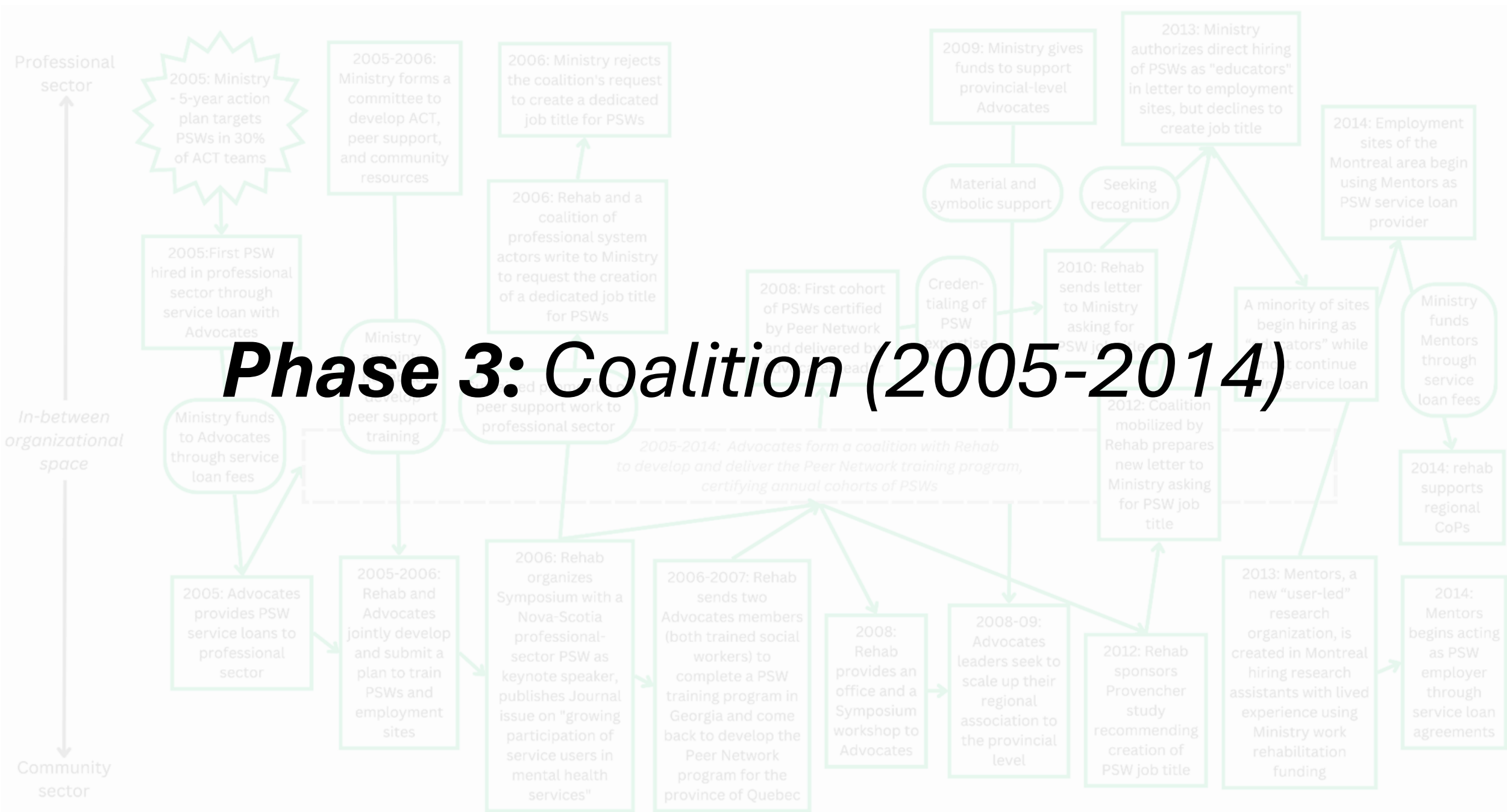
Period 1: Emergence of peer support work

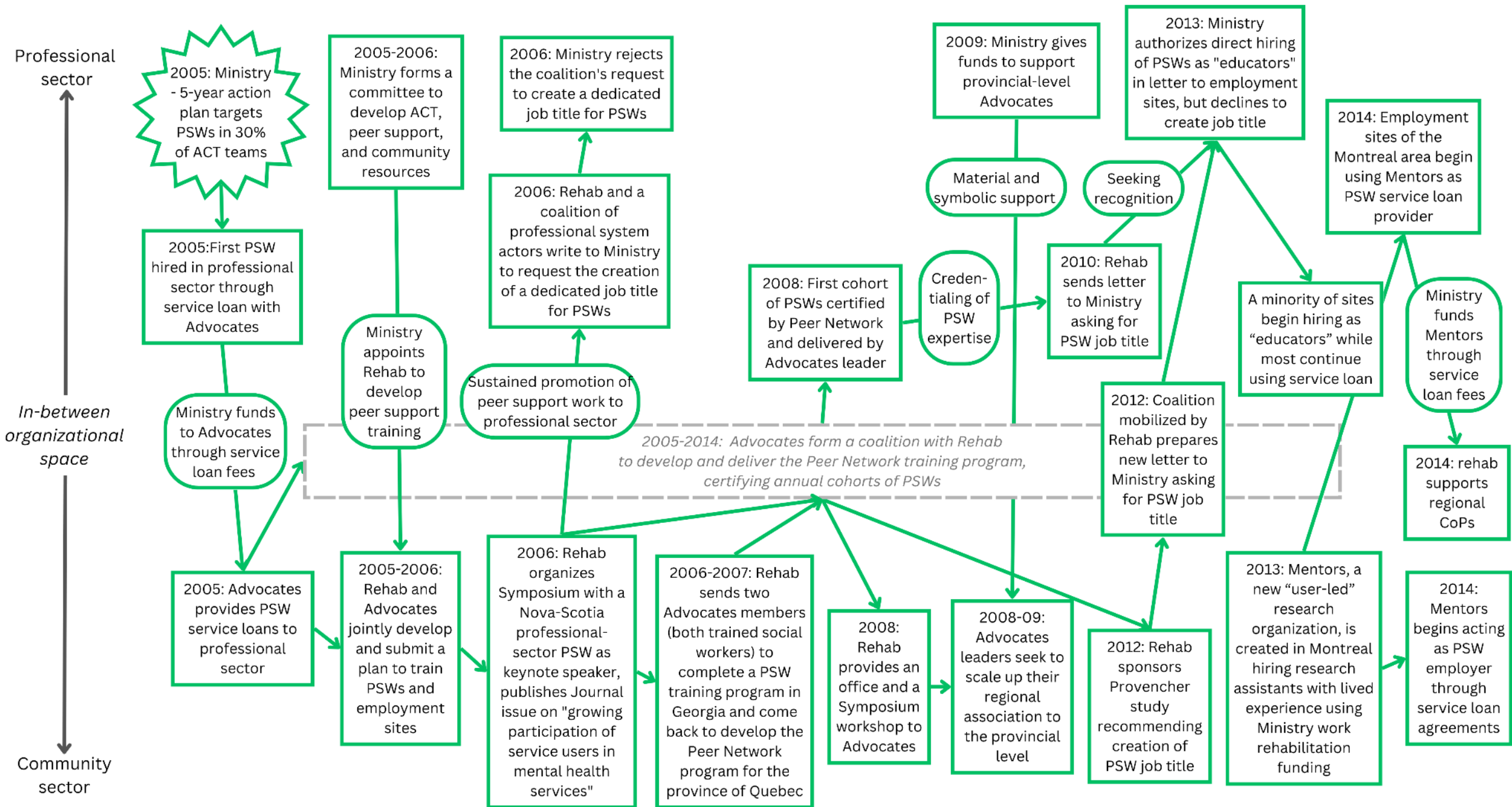


Professional sector
↑
In-between organizational space
↓
Community sector

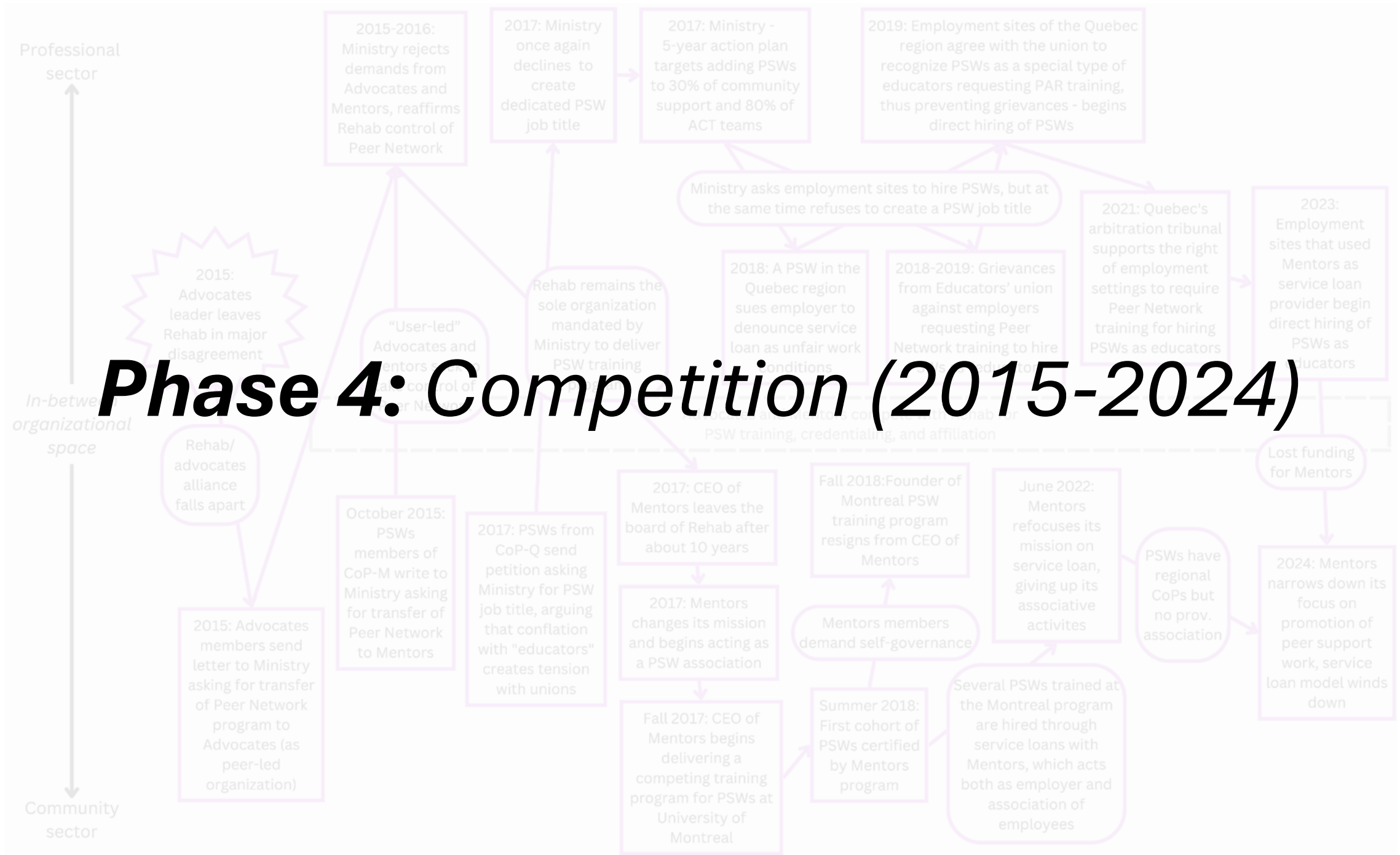


Phase 3: Coalition (2005-2014)





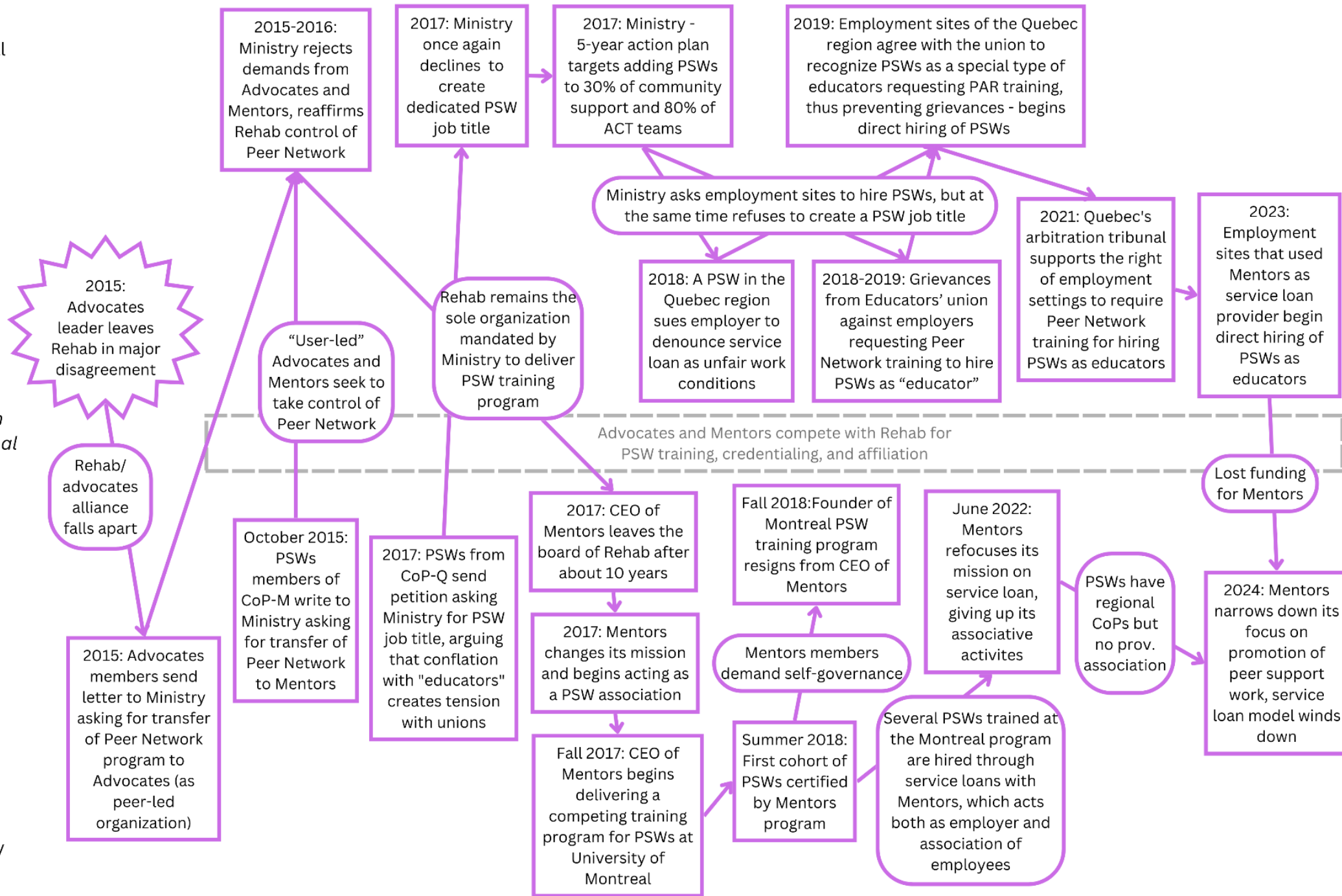
Phase 4: Competition (2015-2024)



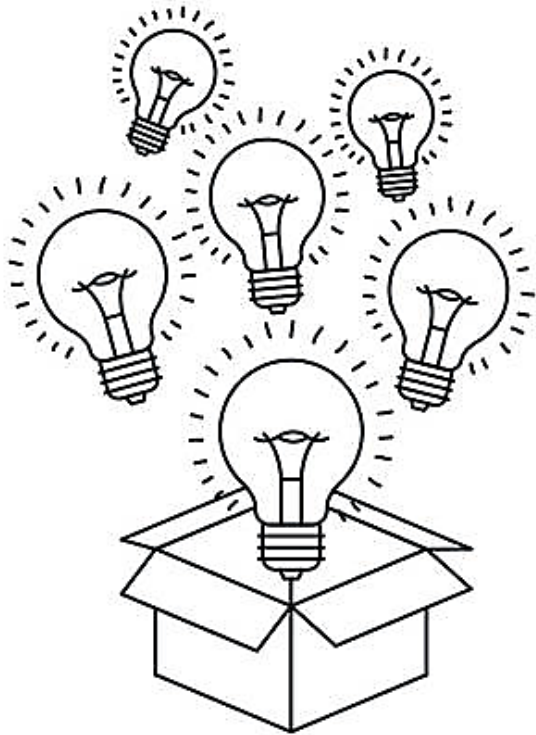
Professional
sector

*In-between
organizational
space*

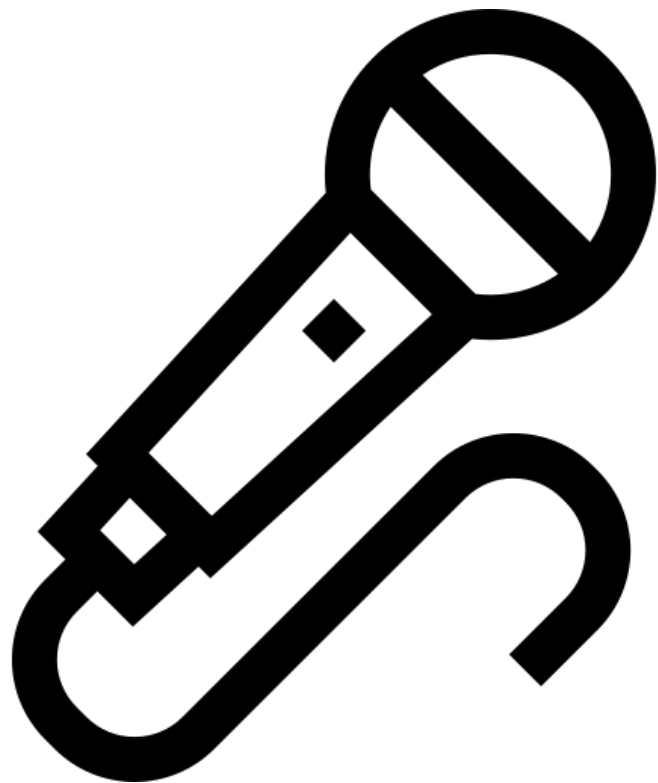
Community
sector



Discussion



- **Persistent liminality** in professional work: the institutional value of “*matter out of place*” (occupational roles in-between clients and professionals) to bridge **experiential** and **expert** forms of knowledge
- How the social construction and evolution of an **organizational space in-between** professional and community sectors over a long period of time both enables and limits the accomplishment of a **professionalization** project



The mic is yours



Thank you!